

DOWNSIZING MANMOHAN

Sonia Gandhi may have distanced herself from the projection of Rahul as the next prime minister by a Machiavellian Arjun Singh but Manmohan Singh's authority has been undermined further

■ By Priya Sahgal

What's wrong with him? An Oxbridge scholar and a former World Bank economist who is widely regarded as the architect of the Indian free market. A moderniser and a man of political moderation. In the age of globalisation, he has all the credentials to be India's ideal brand ambassador. Still, as the country inches towards the general elections, the prime minister has been reminded of his dispensability: you are not the future as you don't have the right surname. And, as always, it

takes an Arjun Singh to make Manmohan Singh feel inadequate.

The wily Thakur from Rewa, Madhya Pradesh, may have been snubbed by the party for his blatant display of sycophancy, but his projection of Rahul Gandhi as the next prime minister has already served his—and like-minded colleagues'—purpose. His demand has further downsized Manmohan and underlined the inevitability of the next Gandhi at the highest seat. (And nobody has missed the joke: the Congress's repudiation of sycophancy!)

Singh can afford to ig-

nore the perfunctory "snub" for the simple reason that Manmohan is on the verge of earning his place in history books: in a few months he will be India's first prime minister to complete his term in office without being a member of the Lok Sabha. He draws his political legitimacy from the singular fact that he is the "choice" of the Supreme Leader. An unexpected beneficiary of Sonia Gandhi's melodramatic renunciation in Central Hall four years ago, Manmohan is an accidental prime minister, and the least political of them all. For Singh, one of the senior

members of the Gandhi durbar, Manmohan is a usurper, and he has been watching this lucky technocrat since the Narasimha Rao raj. And, for the first time in Indian politics, the prime minister's authority has been strictly functional, never political. He remains dutiful, nothing more.

The human resource development minister, who fancies himself to be the conscience-keeper of the party, knows when to strike—and where. He has chosen the weakest of targets. And his Rahul-is-salvation position reflects a clear reading of the Congress mind. The

KEEPER OF THE FAITH: Manmohan (left) with Rahul the hesitant heir apparent